

Designing Equity at Pinterest

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In the summer of 2020, Pinterest, Inc., a company long celebrated for its warm, collaborative culture, became the subject of a public reckoning. Two Black women on Pinterest's policy team came forward with allegations of racial discrimination and pay inequity, and the company's former Chief Operating Officer published a widely read account of systemic gender bias and executive exclusion. The settlements that followed, including a \$22.5 million gender discrimination settlement and a \$50 million commitment to workplace DEI reform, were among the largest of their kind in Silicon Valley history. What made Pinterest's situation particularly striking was not just the severity of the allegations, but the distance between them and the company's public identity. The same organization that listed "knitting" as a core value had, according to its own employees, quietly sustained a workplace culture defined by exclusion, retaliation, and informal power networks that systematically disadvantaged women and employees of color.

Pinterest's case illustrates a pattern that organizational researchers have documented repeatedly: surface-level commitments to diversity and inclusion, when unaccompanied by structural accountability, tend to obscure rather than remedy inequity. Addressing the failures Pinterest's employees described requires intervention at the same level at which they originated: the structure of the organization itself. This paper presents a multilevel DEI intervention framework targeting compensation equity, promotion transparency, psychological safety, and inclusive leadership, along with an evaluation framework designed to assess both the subjective and objective dimensions of inclusion over time.

Needs Analysis

Organizational Background

Pinterest, Inc is a global and publicly traded digital platform which allows users to conduct visual searches, build inspirational boards, and connect with other users on topics ranging from home décor, recipes, fashion, and more. The company was founded by Ben Silbermann, Evan Sharp, and Paul Sciarra in 2009, it is currently headquartered in San Francisco, CA. At its peak, Pinterest was worth \$21 billion (Conger, 2020b), employed approximately 2,000 people, and had 367 million monthly active users consisting of mostly women (Pinterest, 2020). Pinterest's pre-2020 reputation was one of inclusion and collaboration, symbolized through one of its stated company values, "knitting" (Conger, 2020a).

Pinterest's DEI Problem

In the Summer of 2020, public accusations were brought forward against Pinterest, bringing light to a problematic workplace reality and shattering Pinterest's carefully cultivated inclusive reputation. Two black women on Pinterest's policy team, Ifeoma Ozoma and Aericia Shimizu Banks spoke out about being underpaid relative to a white male colleague and retaliated against once asking Pinterest for equal pay (Milstein, n.d.).

Within months, Pinterest's former Chief Operating Officer, Francoise Brougher, filed a lawsuit and published the essay "The Pinterest Paradox: Cupcakes and Toxicity." Brougher's essay claimed that Pinterest marginalized, excluded, and silenced their female executives, preferring the input of male executives despite the company's largely female user base (Swisher, 2020). She described being excluded from board presentations and key decisions, with real decision-making happening among a small circle of male favorites after official meetings had

ended. Brougher's final straw came when she realized her stock option vesting schedule was less favorable than most male executives at her level. She raised the issue with company leaders and was subsequently labeled as lacking in "cross functional relationships," despite previously positive performance reviews. Brougher was terminated during a surprise video call (Swisher, 2020).

Brougher's outcries were quickly verified by former and current employees who described Pinterest's corporate culture as a boy's club, rife with nepotism and exclusion. CEO Ben Silbermann's admitted that building a healthy culture requires far more deliberateness than he had previously exercised (Swisher, 2020). In the end, Pinterest settled Brougher's lawsuit for \$22.5 million, one of the largest gender discrimination settlements in Silicon Valley history (Conger, 2020b).

The actions of Ozoma, Banks, and Brougher not only demonstrated systemic failures like racial discrimination, gender discrimination, pay inequity, and suppression, but they also inspired more action, support, and change. A subsequent lawsuit alleged Pinterest's leadership fostered a culture of racial and gender bias caused financial and reputational harm to the company, ultimately resulting in Pinterest agreeing to commit \$50 million to workplace DEI reforms (Cohen Milstein). Furthermore, in August 2020, 236 employees staged a virtual walkout, signing a petition demanding full transparency around promotion levels, retention, compensation, and calling for the two layers of management reporting to the CEO to consist of at least 25% women and 8% underrepresented minorities (Conger, 2020a). Overall, this controversy highlights how an organization's outward-facing DEI comments can mask deeply inequitable internal practices. Pinterest's reputation as the "nicest place on the internet" hid the hostile experiences of its most

marginalized employees and underscores the need for structural, rather than surface-level, DEI interventions.

Investigation Plan

To gain a more comprehensive understanding of the systemic inequities identified at Pinterest, a multimethod investigation would be employed. This approach combines quantitative surveys, qualitative interviews and focus groups, and structured document review, and is consistent with best practices in organizational diagnosis, which recognize that no single method can fully capture the complexity of inclusion failures across multiple organizational levels.

On the quantitative side, an inclusion climate survey would be administered to all employees. This instrument would assess key variables including psychological safety, employee voice, fairness perceptions of compensation and promotion practices, and indicators of structural bias. Salary distribution data would be collected and disaggregated by race and gender to identify unexplained pay gaps. A structured policy and document review would be conducted to examine existing compensation structures, promotion criteria, and complaint reporting mechanisms, and to benchmark these against peer company practices and industry standards. This review would also examine historical promotion and retention patterns to detect potential disparities over time. Finally, job evaluation data would be gathered to assess internal role comparability and support compensation analysis.

Qualitative data would be gathered through semi-structured interviews and focus groups segmented by demographic identity. These conversations would target employees' experiences of voice and participation in decision-making, perceptions of leadership behavior and allyship, and the degree to which employees feel safe raising concerns. Interview questions would probe

experiences of informal power dynamics, access to leadership networks, and whether employees have witnessed or experienced exclusion or retaliation.

This combination of methods is well suited to Pinterest's diagnostic needs for several reasons. Surveys allow for scalable, systematic measurement across the full workforce and enable statistical comparison across demographic groups, essential for identifying where employee experiences diverge. Quantitative compensation and job evaluation analyses provide objective, auditable evidence of pay inequity that self-report data alone cannot establish. Qualitative interviews and focus groups complement these by surfacing the lived experiences and contextual meaning behind the numbers, particularly the informal dynamics that structured instruments may not fully capture. Together, these methods provide both structural evidence and rich experiential insight, creating a strong empirical foundation for the intervention that follows.

Intervention Overview

Pinterest's DEI challenges reflect systemic failures in organizational fairness, leadership accountability, and inclusion climate, rather than isolated instances of individual bias. As outlined in the needs analysis, employees reported pay inequities, exclusion from decision-making, retaliation after raising concerns, and a broader "boys' club" culture reinforced through informal power networks. These issues suggest that inequities were embedded not only in formal systems, such as compensation and promotion processes, but also in the everyday interactions and informal structures that shape employees' access to opportunity and influence, which is consistent with research demonstrating that inclusion is shaped across organizational, leadership, and group levels simultaneously (Shore et al., 2018). Inclusion, defined as employees' ability to feel valued, respected, and able to meaningfully contribute and influence decisions, serves as the

mechanism through which diversity translates into positive outcomes (Ferdman, 2014). In the case of Pinterest, breakdowns in inclusion, particularly around voice, fairness, and decision-making access, appear to have driven many of the negative employee experiences described.

This diagnosis has direct implications for intervention design. Accordingly, addressing these challenges requires a comprehensive, multilevel intervention that targets both structural and behavioral drivers of inequity. Specifically, this intervention includes (a) organizational-level changes to policies and processes to increase transparency and accountability, (b) group and interpersonal practices designed to enhance inclusion and employee voice, and (c) training programs that support sustainable behavior change across the organization. At the organizational level, these efforts focus on strengthening formal systems that govern compensation, promotion, and reporting. At the group and interpersonal level, the intervention targets employees' day-to-day experiences of belonging, voice, and psychological safety. Finally, training is positioned as a reinforcing mechanism that equips employees and leaders with the skills necessary to enact inclusive behaviors within these improved systems. Taken together, this multilevel approach ensures that inclusion is embedded into both organizational structures and everyday practices, rather than treated as a standalone initiative.

Organizational-Level Interventions

Pay Transparency and Compensation Justice

A central issue identified at Pinterest was the underpayment of women and Black employees, compounded by a lack of transparency in how compensation decisions were made. When employees do not have visibility into compensation structures, inequities can persist without detection, and pay secrecy has been shown to undermine perceptions of fairness and negatively impact employee attitudes and behavior (Bamberger & Belogolovsky, 2010). From an

organizational perspective, compensation systems are a primary mechanism through which fairness is communicated, as organizational practices signal what is valued and rewarded within the organization (Leslie, 2019). In the case of Pinterest, the absence of transparent and standardized compensation practices likely contributed to both actual inequities and perceptions of inequity among employees.

To address these issues, Pinterest should implement a structured and transparent compensation system. First, the organization should establish a clearly defined compensation philosophy that outlines how pay decisions are made and what factors are considered in determining compensation. Industrial-organizational (I/O) consultants should be engaged to conduct comprehensive job analyses to ensure that roles are evaluated based on their responsibilities, required competencies, and organizational impact. This should be followed by external market benchmarking to ensure that compensation levels are competitive and aligned with industry standards. Based on this analysis, Pinterest should develop and publish salary bands and leveling criteria for all roles, providing employees with clear expectations regarding compensation progression and reducing ambiguity around pay decisions.

In addition, Pinterest should implement regular third-party pay equity audits, conducted every two to three years, to systematically identify and address disparities across demographic groups. These audits serve as an objective mechanism for evaluating whether compensation practices align with the organization's stated commitment to equity. To further reinforce accountability, any compensation decisions that fall outside of established salary bands should require formal documentation and justification, ensuring that deviations are intentional, defensible, and subject to review. Finally, aggregated pay equity findings should be shared at a high level with employees to promote transparency and signal organizational commitment to

fairness.

Taken together, these practices aim to reduce both actual pay inequities and perceptions of unfairness by increasing transparency, standardization, and accountability within compensation systems. By addressing compensation as a structural issue rather than an individual one, this intervention directly targets one of the core drivers of Pinterest's DEI challenges and reinforces a more equitable organizational environment.

Structured Promotion Process

Another critical issue identified at Pinterest was that promotion decisions were perceived to be driven by informal networks and favoritism rather than objective performance. When advancement opportunities rely on informal access to leadership or visibility rather than clearly defined criteria, employees from underrepresented groups are disproportionately disadvantaged, particularly if they are excluded from key conversations or decision-making spaces. This dynamic reinforces existing power structures and contributes to perceptions of unfairness, which can negatively impact engagement, trust, and retention. From an I/O perspective, structured decision-making processes are essential for reducing subjectivity and bias, particularly in high-stakes outcomes such as promotions (Bohnet, 2016).

To address this issue, Pinterest should implement a standardized promotion process with clearly defined and consistently applied criteria. Promotion decisions should require documented evidence across multiple domains, including demonstrated performance outcomes, measurable business impact, and relevant behavioral competencies. In addition, organizations should require calibration discussions across teams or departments to ensure consistency in how criteria are applied and to reduce variability driven by individual managers. Formal documentation of promotion decisions should be required, creating transparency and accountability while also

allowing for auditability over time. Providing employees with visibility into promotion criteria and expectations will further reduce ambiguity and help ensure that all employees understand what is required for advancement.

By formalizing and standardizing promotion processes, Pinterest can reduce reliance on informal networks and increase equity in career progression. This approach not only addresses structural sources of bias but also improves perceptions of procedural fairness, which is a key driver of employee attitudes and organizational commitment (McKay & Avery, 2015).

Ultimately, creating a more transparent and consistent promotion system will help ensure that advancement opportunities are based on merit rather than access, directly addressing one of the core contributors to the organization's DEI challenges.

Formal Complaint and Anti-Retaliation Policy

Employees at Pinterest reported retaliation after raising concerns, indicating a breakdown in trust in organizational reporting systems; this undermines employee voice and psychological safety, both of which are central to inclusive organizational climates (Shore et al., 2018). To rebuild this trust, Pinterest should implement a formalized complaint and anti-retaliation system that prioritizes both accessibility and accountability. This includes establishing anonymous reporting channels and clearly defined reporting pathways through Human Resources. The organization should also communicate clear investigation timelines and transparent escalation procedures so employees understand how complaints will be handled. Internal communication campaigns should be used to increase awareness of these systems and reinforce their credibility.

Critically, anti-retaliation protections must be actively enforced rather than passively stated. Pinterest should monitor employee outcomes following a complaint, including changes in performance evaluations, job assignments, or employment status, to detect and address potential

retaliation. Requiring documentation and oversight in post-complaint decisions can further reduce the likelihood of retaliatory behavior. By strengthening reporting systems and reinforcing protections, this intervention aims to rebuild trust, increase employee voice, and create an environment in which concerns can be raised and addressed without fear which is critical for effective reporting systems, as employees are more likely to speak up when protections against retaliation are credible and consistently enforced (Miceli et al., 2008).

Group and Interpersonal-Level DEI Practices

Employee Resource Groups (ERGs)

To improve employees' day-to-day experiences of inclusion, Pinterest should establish and formalize Employee Resource Groups (ERGs). ERGs provide community, support, and advocacy for underrepresented employees while also serving as a channel for organizational feedback and have been shown to enhance inclusion and belonging when supported with executive sponsorship and organizational resources (Catalino et al., 2022). These groups should be aligned to key identity groups, such as women and racial or ethnic minoritized groups and supported with executive sponsorship, dedicated budgets, and organizational resources. In addition to fostering connections, ERGs should offer structured opportunities for mentorship, networking, and direct communication with leadership. By integrating ERGs into organizational processes, Pinterest can enhance employee voice, increase visibility of underrepresented groups, and promote a stronger sense of belonging.

Engagement Pulse Surveys

To continuously assess employee experiences, Pinterest should implement quarterly engagement pulse surveys that go beyond representation metrics, using survey data to guide action planning and organizational accountability (McNiel, 2025). These surveys should measure

key dimensions such as inclusion, psychological safety, fairness perceptions, and employee voice. Results should be segmented by demographic groups to identify disparities across populations. Importantly, high-level findings should be shared transparently with employees, along with clear action plans to address identified concerns. This process enables the organization to monitor its inclusion climate over time while reinforcing accountability and demonstrating responsiveness to employee feedback.

Structured 1:1 Check-In Policy

To strengthen manager-employee relationships and improve communication, Pinterest should implement a structured 1:1 check-in policy. Managers should be required to hold regular one-on-one meetings with their direct reports, such as on a biweekly or monthly basis. These meetings should follow a general framework that includes discussion of career development, workload and support needs, and employee feedback or concerns. Importantly, these conversations should be positioned as supportive and developmental rather than evaluative, encouraging open dialogue, as regular manager-employee interactions are critical for fostering psychological safety and employee voice within teams (Shore et al., 2018). By institutionalizing consistent check-ins, the organization can increase employee voice, build trust, and ensure that concerns are addressed proactively.

Training Programs

Training Philosophy

Training is included in this intervention as a supporting mechanism designed to reinforce structural and interpersonal changes, rather than serve as a standalone solution. In organizations where inequities are embedded within formal systems, such as compensation, promotion, and reporting processes, training alone is unlikely to produce meaningful or sustained change as

diversity initiatives implemented in isolation often fail to produce intended outcomes and can result in symbolic or ineffective change if not aligned with organizational systems (Leslie, 2019). In the case of Pinterest, training must therefore be aligned with updated organizational practices and positioned as a tool that enhances employees' ability to operate within more equitable systems. This approach reduces the risk of symbolic or ineffective interventions and ensures that training contributes to real behavioral change.

To maximize effectiveness, training will be delivered using interactive and applied methods that emphasize skill development and real-world application as training effectiveness research consistently shows that active, practice-based methods enhance learning and transfer to the workplace (Salas et al., 2012). These methods will include scenario-based simulations grounded in Pinterest-relevant situations, role-playing exercises, and decision-making labs that allow participants to actively practice inclusive behaviors. Participants will also engage in structured reflection and action planning to support the transfer of training into the workplace. This applied approach ensures that employees are not only aware of inclusive practices but are also equipped to implement them in their daily interactions and decision-making processes.

Inclusive Leadership Training

Inclusive leadership training will be delivered to managers and executives, as they play a central role in shaping employees' day-to-day experiences of inclusion. Leadership behaviors directly influence access to opportunities, participation in decision-making, and perceptions of fairness, all of which were identified as key issues at Pinterest. This training will focus on practical, behavior-based competencies, including recognizing exclusion in decision-making processes, facilitating inclusive meetings, and conducting fair and consistent performance evaluations. By targeting specific leadership behaviors, the training aims to improve how

inclusion is enacted in everyday managerial practices, as leadership behaviors play a central role in shaping employee experiences of inclusion and access to opportunities. Inclusive leadership has been linked to stronger employee engagement, belonging, and team performance in practice (Sarangi, 2025).

The training will incorporate realistic scenarios that reflect challenges specific to Pinterest's context, such as managing team discussions, evaluating employee contributions, and making promotion-related decisions. Leaders will be encouraged to reflect on how their behaviors influence team dynamics and to develop actionable strategies for improvement. By emphasizing application and accountability, this training ensures that inclusive leadership is not treated as an abstract concept, but as a set of observable and measurable behaviors that directly impact employee experience.

Bystander Intervention Training

Bystander intervention training will be integrated to equip employees with the skills needed to respond to exclusionary or unfair behavior in interpersonal settings. This component focuses on helping employees speak up safely, support colleagues, and challenge problematic behavior in a constructive manner. Given that many instances of bias and exclusion occur in group contexts, empowering bystanders to intervene can play a critical role in shaping team norms as research shows that individuals can effectively confront and interrupt biased behavior, particularly when they feel supported and perceive intervention as socially acceptable (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008). Together, bias interruption and bystander training create both individual and collective accountability for maintaining an inclusive environment, ensuring that employees are not only aware of inequities but also prepared to address them in real time.

Taken together, this multilevel intervention addresses both the structural systems and

interpersonal dynamics that contributed to Pinterest's DEI failures. By increasing transparency and accountability in organizational processes, strengthening inclusion in day-to-day interactions, and equipping employees with the skills to support behavior change, this approach is designed to create a more equitable, inclusive, and sustainable organizational environment.

Evaluation Metrics

To evaluate the effectiveness of the multilevel DEI intervention at Pinterest, we are proposing a mixed-methods evaluation framework - drawing on both quantitative and qualitative data sources collected at multiple time points. The primary survey-based method will involve administering a validated inclusion of climate survey before the intervention begins and at regular intervals after implementation. This pre/post design will allow for meaningful comparison of employee perceptions over time. Ferdman (2014) conceptualizes inclusion as a dynamic, multilevel experience encompassing feelings of safety, respect, voice, and authenticity - all of which map directly onto the failures Pinterest employees described, including being silenced after raising pay concerns and being excluded from key decision-making. The inclusion climate survey will be adapted to capture these dimensions, drawing on Nishii's (2013) measure of inclusive climates, which assesses whether employees feel safe voicing grievances, whether the environment is non-threatening, and whether all employees' ideas are taken seriously (as cited in Shore et al., 2018). Alongside this, psychological safety will be measured as a discrete construct, given that research consistently demonstrates its role as a mediator between leader inclusion and meaningful outcomes such as learning from failures, creative work engagement, and unit performance (Shore et al., 2018). Quarterly pulse surveys, segmented by demographic group, will track ongoing perceptions of fairness, voice, and belonging between the larger pre/post assessments, providing a continuous monitoring mechanism. A benchmark of no more

than a 5% gap in inclusion scores between demographic groups will be used as a target, and results will be throughout the organization with accompanying action plans to reinforce accountability. Stay interviews, which is the structural opposite of exit interviews, will be conducted with employees across identity groups to gather qualitative insight into what is working and what continues to fall short (West, 2024). These conversations are particularly important given that Pinterest employees with marginalized identities, including Black women and female executives, faced retaliation and exclusion that quantitative metrics alone would not fully capture. Employee Resource Group (ERG) feedback will serve as an additional qualitative data source, with structured mechanisms for ERGs to report on their reach, perceived organizational support, and areas of unmet need. On the objective side, HR metrics will be collected and tracked over time, including the number and nature of formal complaints filed, average complaint resolution times, outcomes of the third-party pay equity audits, and promotion and retention rates disaggregated by race and gender. Finally, qualitative focus groups segmented by demographic identity will be conducted at 12 and 24 months (about 2 years) post-implementation to surface lived experiences of inclusion that survey instruments may miss.

An effective intervention will be evidenced by a convergence of improved subjective and objective indicators. On the survey side, success will be marked by statistically significant improvements in inclusion climate scores and psychological safety perceptions across all employee groups, with particular attention to historically marginalized employees, which are the very groups who reported the most acute exclusion at Pinterest. Shore et al. (2018) argue that genuinely inclusive organizations are characterized by employees experiencing belonging alongside uniqueness. That is, they feel they belong without having to suppress who they are. An effective intervention at Pinterest, then, would show not only increased belonging scores but also

increased scores on authenticity items, indicating that women and employees of color feel able to bring their full selves to work without fear of retaliation. Relatedly, Ferdman (2014) emphasizes that inclusion requires employees to have genuine influence on decision-making, a dimension that was egregiously violated at Pinterest (Wittenberg-Cox, 2020). A significant increase in scores on decision-making influence items would therefore be a key marker of success. On the objective side, a reduction in HR complaints and retaliation-related grievances, shorter complaint resolution timelines, and demonstrated pay equity across demographic groups following third-party audit would all signal that systemic changes are taking hold. Effective interventions should also show reduced turnover among women and underrepresented minorities, as research consistently links perceived inclusion to higher organizational commitment and lower withdrawal intentions (Shore et al., 2018). From a qualitative standpoint, focus group data should reveal thematic shifts, from narratives of exclusion, tokenism, and fear of speaking up, to experiences of being heard, valued, and supported. A less-than 5% gap in inclusion scores between demographic groups across pulse survey waves would indicate that the intervention is reducing the differential experiences that have historically characterized Pinterest's culture.

In contrast, an ineffective intervention would be signaled by persistently low or stagnant inclusion and psychological safety scores, particularly among women and employees of color, continued clustering of formal complaints without resolution, and persisting pay disparities flagged by the equity audit. Qualitative data revealing that employees still feel unable to raise concerns without fear of retaliation - the very pattern that initially exposed Pinterest's DEI failures, would suggest the cultural and structural changes have not yet translated into day-to-day employee experience. Jones and King (2013) note that organizations with low perceived support create conditions in which stigmatized employees are less likely to disclose concerns or engage

authentically, and are more likely to conceal their true experiences, a dynamic that would make Pinterest's informal reporting culture persist despite formal policy changes. If pulse survey gaps between demographic groups remain above 5% or widen over time, or if ERG feedback reveals that executive sponsors are not meaningfully engaging with underrepresented employees' concerns, these would be clear indicators that the intervention requires recalibration. In sum, the evaluation framework proposed here is designed to hold Pinterest accountable not just on paper, but in the lived experiences of the employees who, in 2020, risked their livelihoods to demand better.

Conclusion

Pinterest's 2020 reckoning was, at its core, a story about the gap between organizational rhetoric and organizational reality. The company's carefully maintained reputation for inclusion did not protect the Black women who were underpaid and retaliated against, the female executive who was excluded from decisions and then terminated for raising the issue, or the hundreds of employees who felt compelled to stage a virtual walkout to be heard. What protected and perpetuated these inequities was a set of organizational structures and informal norms that operated largely out of view: opaque compensation systems, promotion decisions driven by access rather than merit, and a reporting culture in which speaking up carried real professional risk.

The intervention framework proposed here is designed to address those structures directly. Pay transparency and third-party equity audits target the compensation systems that allowed racial and gender disparities to persist undetected. Standardized promotion criteria and calibration processes reduce reliance on the informal networks that systematically disadvantaged

underrepresented employees. Formal anti-retaliation protections and anonymous reporting channels aim to rebuild the trust that Pinterest's employees lost when the consequences of speaking up proved to be professional rather than remedial. Employee resource groups, structured check-ins, and pulse surveys work to make inclusion a continuously monitored organizational condition rather than an assumed one. And training, positioned here explicitly as a reinforcing mechanism rather than a standalone solution, equips employees and leaders with the behavioral skills needed to operate within these more equitable systems.

No intervention framework, however carefully designed, can guarantee culture change. What it can do is remove the structural conditions that make inequity easy and accountability difficult. Pinterest has already made both public and financial commitments to improvement; the critical question is whether those commitments will translate into sustained, system-level action. The employees who spoke out did so at personal and professional risk, and meaningful change requires honoring that by following through with deliberate, consistent effort. The framework proposed here is offered as one evidence-based path toward that goal.

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